

GAUNTLET

Official Rulebook

Version 0.6.3

Welcome to Gauntlet

Gauntlet is a two-player tactical card-and-territory game. Each player builds a Deck, chooses one of six factions and one of that faction's Leaders, and contributes three Territories to a shared six-Territory battlefield called the **Gauntlet**.

Players advance toward one another, fight battles, occupy and capture opposing Territories, develop Assets, and pursue faction-specific plans. The normal shared victory is to **run the Gauntlet** by either capturing the Territory at the opponent's end or winning that opponent's Last Stand.

How to Use This Rulebook

The rulebook is organized to teach the game in the order a new player needs it.

- **Part I — Learn to Play** explains the shared game from components through victory.
- **Part II — Complete Shared Rules** contains deck construction and technical interaction rules.
- **Part III — Factions** explains the six factions, their Leaders, components, procedures, and alternate victories.
- **Part IV — Reference** provides compact turn and battle sequences, a glossary, and the copyright and playtest-use notice.

Major chapters use two layers. **How it works** teaches the ordinary rule in direct language. **Complete rules** gives exact timing, exceptions, and edge cases. Read the How it works layer first when learning; use Complete rules to answer precise questions.

Game at a Glance

Each player begins on the Territory at their own end of a six-Territory battlefield. On your turn, capture if eligible, draw a card, take one Action during either Opening or Denouement, and Advance, Hold, or Fall Back during Movement. Entering the opponent's position creates a pending battle.

Before that battle begins, applicable Diplomat Terms resolve. If the pending battle continues, Onset begins the battle. Each player may risk one card from Hand as a Gambit, then draws a temporary three-card Reserve and may choose one card as a Tactic. Card effects and dice determine the winner. The loser retreats, and the winner takes or keeps the contested position.

Winning an attack does not normally capture a Territory immediately. Your controlled Territories form a contiguous **Front Line** from your own end. During your Capture step, if your token is on or beyond the next opposing Territory past that Front Line, advance the Front Line by one Territory. This makes deep Occupation possible without creating non-contiguous control.

How to Win

The normal shared victory is to **run the Gauntlet**. You win immediately when you either:

1. capture the Territory at your opponent's end of the Gauntlet; or
2. win your opponent's Last Stand.

These are independent routes. A Last Stand does not require control of the final Territory first, but it does require a separate legal movement sequence after the battle that forced the opponent beyond the Gauntlet.

Some factions also have an alternate victory condition described in Part III.

Golden Rules

- When two rules or effects genuinely conflict, follow the more specific one. If both can apply, use normal timing and order instead; specificity does not undo an effect that has already been applied.
 - **May** means an effect is optional. **Must** means it is required.
 - Follow instructions in the order written.
 - Complete as much of an instruction as possible unless the missing part is a required cost, requirement, or target.
-

Part I — Learn to Play

1. Components

How it works

For a first game, use two prepared or recommended game packages. Each player needs one complete game package, one Player Token, and a six-sided die. The two players' three-Territory sets join to form the six-position Gauntlet.

Complete rules

Each player needs:

- one complete game package;
- one **Player Token**; and
- one six-sided die.

The players may share a die.

Each player's complete game package contains:

- one faction;
- one Leader Card from that faction;
- one **Deck** of ordinary playable cards;
- three different Territory Cards; and
- any components required by that faction or Leader.

Together, both players' Territory Cards form the **Gauntlet**, a single six-Territory column. The exact construction requirements for a custom Deck appear in Chapter 10. Faction packages and their starting states appear in Part III.

2. Cards, Zones, and the Play Area

How it works

Keep every group of cards visibly separate. Your Hand is the permanent private set of cards you hold between turns. Your Draw Pile supplies cards; the Discard Pile is recyclable; the Graveyard normally is not. Assets remain face up in your Asset Bank.

A battle creates three temporary areas: a Gambit set from Hand, a three-card Reserve drawn from the Draw Pile, and a Tactic chosen from that Reserve.

Printed card effects

A card may have several printed effects. The way it is used determines which effect applies.

- **Action:** normally play from Hand by taking an Action during Opening or Denouement.
- **Gambit:** set from Hand during a battle.
- **Tactic:** choose from Reserve during a battle.
- **Gambit/Tactic:** may be used as either a Gambit or a Tactic.

Only the printed effect being used applies unless a rule says otherwise.

Setting a Gambit or choosing a Tactic places the card in battle without applying its effect immediately. Gambit and Tactic effects apply at their normal reveal stages even when an effect causes the card to become face up early, unless that effect says otherwise.

Faction cards may contain other headings. Those headings use the procedure stated in the relevant faction chapter and do not make a card eligible as a Gambit or Tactic unless it also has a Gambit, Tactic, or Gambit/Tactic effect.

Play area and zones

Draw Pile

The face-down pile formed from the Deck. Draw cards from its top.

Hand

The private cards held by a player. The normal Hand limit is three at end-of-turn Cleanup. Setting the Hand physically aside during a battle does not move those cards to another zone.

Discard Pile

A face-up pile of recyclable cards. When a Draw Pile cannot complete a draw, shuffle the Discard Pile to form a new Draw Pile.

Graveyard

A face-up pile outside normal circulation. Cards there are not reshuffled unless an effect moves them.

Asset Bank

The public area containing a player's banked Assets.

Gambit area

The temporary area containing cards set from Hand as Gambits for the current battle. Gambits normally go to their owners' Graveyards during the Aftermath.

Reserve

A temporary private zone formed during one battle. Each player normally draws three cards to form it. Reserve is separate from Hand, and its owner may inspect and arrange it freely. Cards remaining there normally go to the Discard Pile during the Aftermath.

Tactic area

The temporary area containing cards chosen or added as Tactics for the current battle. Tactics normally go to their owners' Discard Piles during the Aftermath.

Leader and faction area

Keep the Leader and all faction trackers, references, progress cards, and other public faction components together and visible. Part III explains each faction's exact arrangement.

Territories and Player Tokens

Territory orientation shows control: the player a Territory faces controls it. A Player Token shows the player's position. Occupation and control are related but are not the same; Chapter 8 explains how control changes.

Bound cards

A bound card is outside normal zones.

- A face-up bound card is public.

- A face-down bound card may be inspected only by its owner.
- A bound card cannot be played, moved, or affected except as instructed by the effect to which it is bound.
- When the binding ends, follow that effect's instructions.

Actions and Action phases

An **Action** is a spendable allowance. The active player normally has 1 Action each turn.

Opening and **Denouement** are the two normal Action phases. A player normally takes no more than one Action in either phase and no more than one Action total during the turn. Additional Actions increase the turn total but do not create another phase or permit multiple Actions in one phase unless an effect says so directly. Chapter 5 contains the complete Action rules.

3. Setup

How it works

Prepare faction components, then shuffle the remaining cards in your Deck to form your Draw Pile. Draw four, choose one to discard, and keep the other three as your opening Hand.

After seeing your opening selection, secretly arrange your three Territories. Form and reveal the six-Territory Gauntlet, place each Player Token on the Territory at that player's own end, and then roll to determine the first player.

Complete rules

Prepare the game in this order:

1. **Prepare faction components.** Place Leaders, trackers, references, supplemental components, and apply any setup rules that add cards to or remove cards from the Deck.
2. **Prepare Draw Piles and opening Hands.** Shuffle the remaining cards in your Deck to form your Draw Pile. Draw four cards, choose one card from those four, and place it face up in your Discard Pile. The other three cards form your opening Hand.
3. **Arrange Territories.** After seeing your opening Hand and opening discard, secretly arrange your three Territory Cards in a line facing you.
4. **Form the Gauntlet.** Join both Territory lines to create one six-Territory column.
5. **Reveal Territories.** Reveal all six simultaneously. They remain face up unless an effect says otherwise.
6. **Place Player Tokens.** Place each Player Token on the Territory at that player's end of the Gauntlet.
7. **Determine first player.** After both players have chosen their opening discard and arranged their Territories, each player rolls one die. The higher result takes the first turn. Reroll ties.

Starting Territory

Placing a Player Token during setup:

- is not movement;
- does not count as entering the Territory; and
- does not trigger an effect that occurs when the Territory is entered.

An effect that applies continuously, at the beginning of a turn, at the start of a turn, during Capture, or during another named phase may apply during the first turn normally when its requirements are satisfied.

Opening selection and Territory arrangement

The discarded card forms the player's Discard Pile before the first turn begins.

The player chooses the opening discard without knowing who will take the first turn. This procedure is mandatory and does not count as discarding for the cost or effect of another card unless a rule expressly refers to the opening discard.

Territory arrangement occurs after the player has chosen the opening discard and knows the three-card opening Hand. A player may therefore use the known opening Hand and Discard Pile when deciding the order of their Territories.

Recommended play areas

Each player should maintain distinct areas for Draw Pile, Discard Pile, Graveyard, Hand, Asset Bank, Leader and supplemental components, Reserve, Gambit, and Tactic. Cards in different zones must remain visibly separate.

4. Your Turn

How it works

Complete every turn in this order:

Capture → **Draw** → **Opening** → **Movement** → **Denouement** → **Cleanup**

You normally take one Action per turn. Take it during either your **Opening** or your **Denouement**.

During Movement, choose to **Advance**, **Hold**, or **Fall Back**. Conduct any battle immediately. After Movement and any resulting battle are complete, proceed to the Denouement.

Complete rules

Capture

Resolve the active player's Capture step using the Front Line rules in Chapter 8.

Apply effects and check victory conditions that occur after Capture before drawing.

Draw

Draw one card using the normal Draw Pile and Discard Pile rules.

Opening

Opening is the Action phase before Movement.

The active player may take their Action during Opening if the chosen Action is legal during that phase.

Movement

The active player chooses Advance, Hold, or Fall Back. Resolve movement one position at a time and conduct any battle caused by movement immediately.

When movement begins a battle, that movement sequence ends and all unused movement from that sequence is lost.

Denouement

Denouement is the Action phase after Movement and any battle caused by it.

The active player may take their Action during Denouement if they did not take it during Opening and the chosen Action is legal during Denouement.

A rule or effect may permit an additional Action or permit an Action despite one having already been taken. Follow the Action rules in Chapter 5.

Cleanup

Apply end-of-turn effects and discard down to the normal Hand limit. All unused Actions and turn-limited Action permissions expire when the turn ends.

Pass the shared active-player marker after Cleanup when that component is in use.

5. Actions, Faction Actions, Faction Abilities, and Assets

How it works

Each turn, take one Action during either your Opening or your Denouement.

An Action may be used to:

- play one card from Hand for its **Action** effect;
- take one legal **Faction Action**; or
- discard one Asset you control.

A **Faction Ability** occurs at its stated timing and does not use your Action unless it expressly says otherwise.

Complete rules

Normal Action limit

The active player normally takes one Action total during the turn.

No more than one Action may normally be taken during Opening, and no more than one Action may normally be taken during Denouement.

The two limits are independent:

1. the total number of Actions the player may take that turn; and
2. the number of Actions the player may take during a particular phase.

Additional Actions

An effect that says a player may take one additional Action that turn increases the total number of Actions available that turn. It does not change the normal limit of one Action in each phase.

Unless another effect expressly permits otherwise, a player with two Actions available must take one during Opening and one during Denouement.

An effect intended to permit more than one Action during the same phase must say so directly. For example:

You may take one additional Action this turn. You may take both Actions during your Denouement.

Permission to take more Actions during a phase does not itself grant an additional Action unless the effect also says that it does.

Directly permitted procedures

A rule or effect may directly permit a card play, faction procedure, or other operation at a stated timing outside Opening or Denouement.

A directly permitted procedure:

- occurs at the stated timing;
- does not count as taking an Action unless the effect expressly says it does;
- does not consume the player's normal Action; and
- does not create another Action phase.

State these effects in terms of the procedure the player may perform. Do not create additional Action phases or implicit same-phase Action permissions.

Playing a card for its Action effect

To play a card for its Action effect:

1. take an Action during a phase in which that Action is legal;
2. play the card from Hand;
3. satisfy all requirements and costs;
4. resolve the Action effect; and
5. put the card in the Discard Pile unless it becomes an Asset, becomes an Overlay, or its effect gives another destination.

Faction Action

A **Faction Action** is a faction-specific option a player may choose when taking an Action.

Every Faction Action entry states whether it is legal during:

- Opening;
- Denouement; or
- either phase.

Taking a Faction Action counts as the player's Action for the turn unless a rule expressly permits another Action.

Faction Ability

A **Faction Ability** is a faction-specific effect used or triggered at its stated timing.

A Faction Ability does not count as taking an Action unless it expressly says otherwise.

Faction references must group Faction Actions separately from Faction Abilities and print the legal phase beside every Faction Action.

Discarding an Asset as an Action

During Opening or Denouement, a player may take an Action to discard one Asset they control.

Using an Asset does not take an Action unless the Asset or another rule expressly says otherwise.

Replacing an Asset

When banking an Asset at the Asset limit, the player may discard one Asset they control to make room and bank the new Asset as part of the same effect.

This replacement is not a separate Action. An effect that prevents an Asset from leaving play also prevents replacing it this way. Any consequence of the replaced Asset leaving play still occurs.

Inquisition Purge exception

The shared Action rules support this faction-specific exception:

Purge — Faction Action, Opening or Denouement: Spend the listed Conviction to perform one Purge. You may take one Action during both your Opening and your Denouement, provided that one of those Actions is Purge.

Purge may be taken as a Faction Action no more than once per turn. It never permits two Actions during the same phase.

A Purge directly permitted by Final Judgment during the Aftermath is a Faction Ability. It does not count as taking the Purge Faction Action and does not activate or consume the two-phase permission above.

Assets and the Asset Bank

A card with an **Asset** effect has an inherent banking Action:

Bank: As an Action, play this card from your Hand and bank it.

Asset is the only banked-card effect heading in v0.6.3. A printed special banking Action overrides the inherent Bank procedure.

A player's Asset limit equals the number of Territories they control. If that limit falls below the number of banked Assets, immediately discard Assets until within the limit; each Asset forced to leave this way is

Removed. Voluntary use/discard and normal self-expiration are not Removal unless expressly stated.

An Asset is **Removed** whenever a rule or effect forces it to leave play, regardless of destination.

Overlays are not Assets and follow Chapter 12.

6. Movement and Position

How it works

During Movement, choose one:

- **Advance:** move one position toward the opponent's end.
- **Hold:** remain in your current position.
- **Fall Back:** move one position toward your own end.

Entering the opponent's position creates a pending battle.

Complete rules

A **Position** is any Territory or off-board space where a Player Token may be placed under the positioning rules.

A player cannot voluntarily Fall Back beyond their own end of the Gauntlet. Player Tokens cannot move through or past one another.

If an effect grants additional movement, resolve it one position at a time unless the effect says otherwise.

Entering the opponent's position:

1. move the attacking token into the contested position;
2. establish the attacker, defender, contested position, and the attacker's previous position; and
3. create a pending battle.

The pending-battle and Terms procedure in Chapter 7 occurs before the battle reaches Onset.

When movement creates a pending battle, the current movement sequence ends and all unused movement in that sequence is lost, even if the pending battle is later prevented by Terms or another effect.

A player moves again after a battle only when a rule or effect directly permits another movement sequence.

7. Battles

DON'T FORGET THE BOARD Territory. Assets. Then Gambits. This is a memory cue only; it does not alter timing or permission.

Pending Battles, Terms, and Onset

How it works

The pre-battle sequence is:

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

Establish the attacker, defender, and contested position before Terms are offered.

If Terms are accepted, apply the Proposal's Accepted effect. The battle never reaches Onset and does not begin.

If Terms are refused or none are offered, proceed to Onset. The battle begins during Onset.

Complete rules

Pending battle

A pending battle exists after the attacker, defender, contested position, and attacker's previous position have been established but before the battle reaches Onset.

Rules and effects that occur when a battle would begin resolve during this pending-battle timing unless their text gives another timing.

A pending battle is not yet a battle. Battle, victory, loss, and Aftermath triggers do not occur unless the battle reaches Onset.

Terms

When a pending battle involves a Diplomat, resolve the Terms procedure, including any applicable mirror priority, before Onset.

If Terms are accepted:

- apply the Proposal's Accepted effect;
- no battle begins;

- no Onset, Gambit, Reserve, Tactic, battle-result, victory, loss, retreat, or Aftermath trigger occurs; and
- move the players exactly as the Accepted effect instructs.

Unless a Proposal gives a different positional result, accepted Terms use this baseline:

The attacker withdraws. The defender remains at the contested position.

Mutual Disarmament and other specialized positional Proposals retain their printed outcomes.

If Terms are refused or no Terms are offered, proceed to Onset.

Onset

Onset is the formal opening stage of a battle. It is parallel to **Aftermath**, the battle's closing stage.

During Onset:

1. the pending battle becomes an active battle;
2. attacker and defender roles become fixed for that battle; and
3. resolve all effects that apply during Onset or when the battle begins, in the required order.

After all Onset effects resolve, proceed to Gambits.

Use **Onset** as the formal stage name. In ordinary prose, use constructions such as **during Onset** or **at the Onset of the battle**.

Battle Sequence and Outcome

Battle sequence

Conduct an active battle in this order:

1. **Onset**
2. Set Gambits.
3. Set Hands aside and form Reserves.
4. Reveal Gambits.
5. Choose Tactics.
6. Reveal Tactics.
7. Determine the Outcome.
8. Proceed to the **Aftermath**.

Terms are not part of this sequence because they resolve before the battle reaches Onset.

Determine the Outcome

Calculate each player's battle total under the ordinary battle rules.

The higher total wins.

Defensive Edge

Defensive Edge: When the defender has Defensive Edge, the defender wins tied battle totals.

The defender normally has Defensive Edge when:

- the defender controls the contested Territory; or
- the defender is making a Last Stand.

An effect may remove Defensive Edge, including an applicable Arena Territory effect. Defensive Edge is conditional; the defender does not have it merely because they are the defender.

If the tied totals are not resolved by Defensive Edge or another applicable tie-breaking rule, make a Tiebreak Roll.

Tiebreak Roll

Each player rolls one die. Do not apply advantage, disadvantage, card effects, numerical modifiers, or the previous battle totals. The higher roll wins. Reroll further ties.

A rule or effect may modify a Tiebreak Roll only if it expressly refers to a **Tiebreak Roll**.

The Tiebreak Roll is a separate sudden-death procedure. It is not a recalculation or reroll of the original battle totals.

The Aftermath

How it works

After the battle outcome is determined, proceed to the Aftermath. If the battle has a winner, the loser retreats, the winner takes or keeps the contested position, and any additional retreat or Front Line effects occur. If an active battle ends by withdrawal, use the no-winner procedure below. Then clear the battle cards as described below.

Gambits go to the Graveyard. Tactics and cards left in Reserve go to the Discard Pile. Remember: **Gambits go to the Graveyard.**

Complete rules

During the Aftermath, follow these steps in order:

1. Determine the battle result, or record that the battle ended without a winner.
2. Apply effects that replace losing with withdrawal.
3. If the battle still has a winner, apply immediate result triggers.
4. If there is a winner, carry out normal retreat and determine whether the winner becomes the occupier, including replacements.
5. Carry out additional retreats, withdrawals, and final-position effects as applicable.
6. Apply other Aftermath effects that occur before cards leave battle.
7. Clear the battle cards.
8. Apply effects triggered by cards leaving battle or entering another zone.
9. Apply end-of-Aftermath effects, including any that grant follow-up movement.

Normal result

Unless an effect says otherwise:

- a losing attacker returns to the position from which they entered;
- a losing defender retreats one position toward their own end;
- a winning attacker takes the contested position and becomes its occupier if it is an opposing Territory they do not control; and
- a winning defender remains there.

Carry out additional retreats one position at a time. A player cannot retreat through the opponent. A player on their final Territory may retreat beyond the Gauntlet normally.

Clearing battle cards

When battle cards are cleared:

- Gambits go to their owners' Graveyards;
- Tactics go to their owners' Discard Piles; and
- cards remaining in Reserve go to their owners' Discard Piles.

If a card tells you to put it somewhere else, follow the card.

A card returned to its **source** returns to the zone from which it entered battle unless another rule says otherwise.

Result and card-movement triggers

Immediate victory triggers occur before retreat unless the effect states otherwise. Effects that require the final position occur after retreat and Occupation. Effects triggered by cards entering Hand, a Discard Pile, a Graveyard, or another zone occur after the cards move there.

Effects at the **end of the Aftermath** occur after the battle cards are cleared and effects triggered by those moves are applied.

Withdrawal and Retreat

How it works

Retreat and withdrawal move a player the same way. The difference is why the player leaves:

A losing player retreats; a player who leaves without losing withdraws.

Fall Back is the ordinary backward Movement choice and is neither retreat nor withdrawal.

Complete rules

Shared positional procedure

Unless an effect says otherwise, when a player retreats or withdraws from a battle:

- an attacker returns to the position from which they entered the contested position; and
- a defender moves one position toward their own end.

After applying that movement:

- if only the attacker withdrew, the defender remains in the contested position;
- if only the defender withdrew, the attacker remains in the contested position and becomes its occupier if it is an opposing Territory they do not control; and
- if both players withdraw, move the attacker first, then the defender, and neither becomes the occupier because of that withdrawal.

Specific edge-of-Gauntlet and effect instructions continue to override this general procedure.

Retreat

A player retreats because they lost a battle.

The battle has a winner and loser. Apply victory, loss, retreat, Occupation, and other result-dependent effects normally.

Retreat does not count as ordinary movement or withdrawal for effects unless an effect says otherwise.

Withdrawal

A player withdraws when a pending or active battle ends without determining a winner.

There is no winner or loser. Victory, loss, and retreat triggers do not occur.

If withdrawal prevents a pending battle before Onset, no battle or Aftermath occurs.

If an active battle ends by withdrawal at any time after Onset, carry out the withdrawal and complete the remaining non-result steps of the Aftermath. Clear any committed battle cards using their normal destinations. Result-dependent triggers do not occur because the battle has no winner or loser.

Withdrawal does not count as Fall Back or ordinary movement for effects unless an effect says otherwise.

8. Front Line, Occupation, and Capture

How it works

Your controlled Territories always form one unbroken line from your own end of the Gauntlet. That line is your **Front Line**.

Your token may advance beyond your Front Line, but your control advances only from your own end. During Capture, if your token is beyond your Front Line, capture the next opposing Territory immediately beyond that line.

Complete rules

Front Line

A player's **Front Line** is the complete unbroken sequence of Territories they control beginning at their own end of the Gauntlet.

A player cannot control a Territory while an opponent-controlled Territory lies between it and that player's own end.

Position and control are separate:

- **Position** is where the Player Token is.
- **Control** is shown by Territory orientation.
- **Occupation** describes a token holding an opposing Territory or position under the occupation rules.
- **Front Line** is the player's contiguous controlled line from their own end.

A token may be several Territories beyond its Front Line without granting control of the intervening or occupied Territories.

Normal Capture

During the Capture step, if the active player's token is beyond their Front Line, identify the next opponent-controlled Territory immediately beyond that Front Line.

If the token is on or beyond that Territory, capture it by rotating it to face the active player.

Normal Capture advances the Front Line by no more than one Territory per turn, regardless of how far the token has advanced.

The Territory captured during the Capture step is not necessarily the Territory containing the active player's token.

Resolve all capture effects, control changes, Asset-limit changes, Deed interactions, and victory checks using the Territory actually added to the Front Line.

Immediate capture effects

An effect that captures a Territory outside the normal Capture step cannot create non-contiguous control.

Unless the effect expressly advances the Front Line more than once, interpret or rewrite it to:

Advance that player's Front Line one Territory.

Final Territory and Last Stand

Capturing the Territory at the opponent's end immediately runs the Gauntlet and wins. Control of that Territory is not required to initiate a Last Stand. After the opponent is forced beyond their end, an attacker on the final Territory may initiate a Last Stand only through a **new legal movement sequence** that Advances beyond the Gauntlet. Unused movement from the sequence that created the preceding battle cannot carry into the Last Stand.

Occupation

Occupation is the state in which a player's token is on an opposing Territory that player does not control. A player in Occupation is the **occupier**. Deep Occupation does not itself change control; control advances through the Front Line rules above.

Counterattack

A **Counterattack** is a battle initiated by the controller of a Territory against an opponent who is the occupier of that Territory. Because normal Capture advances the Front Line during the occupier's Capture step, the controller normally has the intervening turn to initiate a Counterattack and drive the occupier away.

9. Running the Gauntlet

How it works

There are two normal ways to run the Gauntlet:

- capture the Territory at your opponent's end; or
- force the opponent into a Last Stand and win it.

Either result wins the game immediately.

Complete rules

Run the Gauntlet: A player runs the Gauntlet and wins immediately when that player either captures the Territory at the opponent's end of the Gauntlet or wins the opponent's Last Stand.

Both routes are the normal shared victory condition. Rules and player-facing text may distinguish the **capture route** from the **Last Stand route**, but both are running the Gauntlet.

Faction-specific alternate victories remain separate victory conditions unless their rules expressly describe them otherwise.

Final-Territory Capture Victory

How it works

If your Front Line reaches and captures the Territory at your opponent's end of the Gauntlet, you immediately run the Gauntlet and win.

Complete rules

When a player captures the Territory at the opponent's end of the Gauntlet, that player immediately runs the Gauntlet and wins the game.

This victory check occurs as part of resolving the legal capture. It does not wait for a later phase, step, turn, or additional battle.

The capture may occur through:

- the normal Capture step;
- a Leader ability;

- a faction ability;
- a playable-card effect;
- a Territory effect; or
- any other rule that legally captures that Territory or advances the player's Front Line to include it.

A capture effect is not suspended, delayed, or treated differently merely because the captured Territory is the opponent's final Territory.

If multiple consequences occur from the same capture, resolve the capture and its required control, orientation, Front Line, and immediate capture consequences. The player then wins before proceeding to a later phase or voluntary procedure unless a specific simultaneous-resolution rule requires another order.

Forcing and Winning a Last Stand

How it works

After you win on the opponent's final Territory and force the opponent beyond the Gauntlet, an effect that gives you another movement sequence may let you Advance beyond the Gauntlet and force a Last Stand immediately.

You do not need to control the final Territory first. You do need a separate legal Advance after the battle that forced the opponent beyond the Gauntlet.

Complete rules

When a player loses a battle while positioned on the Territory at their own end of the Gauntlet, that player retreats beyond their end under the normal edge-of-Gauntlet retreat rules. The winner remains on the opposing final Territory unless another rule or effect moves them.

The winner is occupying that Territory while it remains controlled by the opponent.

A player initiates the opponent's Last Stand when all of the following are true:

1. the opponent is positioned beyond their own end of the Gauntlet;
2. the advancing player is positioned on the Territory at the opponent's end;
3. a rule or effect grants the advancing player a new legal movement sequence; and
4. during that sequence, the advancing player Advances beyond the opponent's end of the Gauntlet.

The advancing player does not need to control or have captured the final Territory before initiating the Last Stand.

The movement sequence that caused the preceding battle ended when that battle was created. Unused movement from that sequence cannot carry the attacker directly into the Last Stand. The attacker must receive another movement sequence from a rule or effect.

Conduct the Last Stand under the inherited Last Stand battle rules. The defender normally has Defensive Edge while making a Last Stand unless an effect removes it.

If the attacker wins the Last Stand, the attacker immediately runs the Gauntlet and wins the game.

If the attacker does not initiate a Last Stand, the attacker may remain on the opposing final Territory. The opponent may Counterattack or use any other legal response. If the attacker later captures the final Territory, the attacker wins through the capture route.

Part II — Complete Shared Rules

10. Constructing a Deck

How it works

Choose one faction and one of its two Leaders. Build a Deck of at least 30 cards with no more than 60 total card value. Use Neutral cards and cards from your chosen faction. Then choose three different Territories.

Complete rules

Choose a faction and Leader

Choose one faction, then choose one Leader belonging to that faction. Both players may choose the same faction or Leader.

The Leader Card begins face up and remains available throughout the game.

Build the Deck

A Deck must contain:

- at least **30 cards**;
- no more than **60 total card value**; and
- only Neutral cards and cards belonging to the selected faction.

Unless marked **Unique**, a card may appear in any quantity permitted by the available card pool. A Unique card is limited to one copy in the Deck.

Choose Territories

Choose exactly three different Territory Cards.

- No more than one may be an **Arena**.
- Territory Cards are not part of the Deck.
- Territories do not count toward the 30-card minimum or 60-value maximum.
- Both players may choose the same Territory titles.

Supplemental components

Prepare all components required by the chosen faction and Leader.

Unless a rule says otherwise, supplemental components:

- are not part of the Deck;
 - are not shuffled into the Draw Pile;
 - cannot be drawn, played, discarded, banked, or placed in the Graveyard; and
 - do not count toward deck size or card value.
-

11. Detailed Card and Timing Rules

How it works

Use this chapter for shared timing, replacement, reveal, banked Assets, bound cards, copied/repeated effects, granted movement, and battles ending without a winner.

Complete rules

- **May** is optional; **Must** is required.
- Follow instructions in order.
- More-specific rules prevail only when rules genuinely conflict.
- An effect applies only at its stated timing and cannot be canceled after it has applied.

Inherited interaction rules

Shared-timing rule

When multiple controlled effects would apply at the same time:

1. the attacker applies one effect they control;
2. the defender applies one effect they control;
3. continue alternating until no effects remain at that timing.

Each player chooses the order of effects they control. Simultaneous reveal does not mean effects are applied simultaneously.

Multiple Gambits or Tactics

An effect may allow more than the normal limit. Unless stated otherwise, that permission is optional. When several Tactics are chosen at the same choice, choose them simultaneously; later additional Tactics use the shared rule below.

Replacements and revisions

A replacement takes the same role as the card it replaces.

- A replacement Gambit must be Gambit-eligible.
- A replacement Tactic must be Tactic-eligible.
- Place it in the face state instructed by the replacing effect.
- Replacement does not reopen an earlier timing window.

- Only effects whose timing remains available and that have not yet been applied may be applied.

When an effect lets a player revise a choice, the revised choice does not create another reveal, response, or replacement opportunity unless stated otherwise.

Reveal and information

To reveal a face-down card, turn it face up and leave it face up.

To reveal a Hand or Reserve, its owner shows the entire zone to the opponent. The cards remain in that zone.

Negation

A negated card has no effect but remains in battle. Unless stated otherwise, a negated Gambit still goes to its owner's Graveyard and a negated Tactic still goes to its owner's Discard Pile.

An effect cannot be negated after it has been applied.

Adopted v0.6.3 card procedures

Gambit and Tactic effect headings

v0.6.3 no longer uses **Battle** as a printed effect heading.

- **Gambit/Tactic** means the same printed effect is available when the card is committed as either a Gambit or a Tactic. On the card face, this heading is stacked as Gambit/ over Tactic to preserve the narrow heading column.
- **Gambit** means the effect is available only when the card is committed as a Gambit.
- **Tactic** means the effect is available only when the card is committed as a Tactic.

The heading identifies eligible battle-card roles; it does not change the effect's printed timing. An effect applies only when its stated timing is reached. If a Gambit or Tactic effect states no later timing, it applies when that card is revealed in that role.

In general prose, use **Gambit effect**, **Tactic effect**, or **Gambit or Tactic effect** as applicable. When a card directly refers to its own printed **Gambit/Tactic** heading, it may say **its Gambit/Tactic effect**.

Inherent banking Action and Asset text

A card with an **Asset** effect has an inherent banking Action:

Bank: As an Action, play this card from your Hand and bank it.

This inherent Action does not need to be printed on the card.

Asset is the only banked-card effect heading in v0.6.3. Asset text may be continuous, triggered, optional, or expressly usable as an Action while the card is banked. The former **Activate** heading is retired. An Asset ability that says `as an Action` still uses the applicable Action permission.

If a card has a printed Action effect that provides a special banking procedure, use that procedure instead. A special banking Action may impose costs, bind cards, draw cards, grant another Action, limit copies, or otherwise change what happens when the card is banked.

For rules and effects that refer to an Action effect that banks a card, the inherent Bank Action counts as such an effect.

Cards whose only printed Action was `Bank this card.` therefore omit that Action section in v0.6.3.

Directly permitted card procedures do not spend another Action

When a rule or effect directly instructs or permits a player to play, bank, place, reveal, or otherwise use a card at a stated timing, that procedure is part of resolving that rule or effect. It does not spend or require another Action unless expressly stated.

Cards therefore do not need phrases such as:

- `without spending an Action;`
- `without spending another Action;`
- `without taking an Action; OR`
- `without taking additional Actions.`

An instruction that expressly says **as an Action, take an Action**, or otherwise identifies an Action still uses the applicable Action permission.

Battle scope in standard v0.6.3

The standard v0.6.3 game is 1v1, so every battle involves both players. A battle-timed effect on a player's card therefore does not need to say `in a battle involving you`. The printed timing and other conditions still determine whether the effect can apply.

Effect-granted movement and new movement sequences

When an effect grants movement, apply the normal movement rules unless it says otherwise.

- If the effect modifies a movement sequence already in progress, the granted movement remains part of that sequence.
- If the effect grants movement while no movement sequence is in progress, it begins a new movement sequence.

- Effect-granted movement may create a pending battle and may initiate a legal Last Stand unless expressly prohibited.
- When movement creates a pending battle, that movement sequence ends and unused movement from it is lost normally.

Cards therefore do not need affirmative text saying that granted movement may start or create a battle. Negative exceptions remain printed.

Additional Tactics use the shared Tactic rules

When an effect permits an **additional Tactic**:

- it must be eligible for the Tactic role;
- before Tactics are revealed, it is set face down with the other chosen Tactics;
- after Tactics are revealed, it is played face up;
- only timing still available may apply;
- choosing it does not reopen an earlier choice, reveal, or response window; and
- it uses the normal Tactic destination unless an effect gives another destination.

Unless an effect says otherwise, the source of a Tactic is the player's **Reserve**.

Multiple applicable +N Reserve and +N Tactic instructions add together unless a rule or effect expressly says otherwise.

Sanctions

A card whose title begins **Sanctions:** is a **Sanction**.

When a Sanction is played, placed, or banked because an opponent refused its owner's Terms:

- that opponent remains associated with that Sanction for as long as it remains in play; and
- unless the Sanction says otherwise, after that opponent accepts the owner's Terms, put the Sanction in its owner's Discard Pile.

A Sanction may state additional removal conditions. Cards therefore do not need to repeat identification of the refusing opponent or the default expiration after later acceptance.

Asset Removal

Remove is a defined Asset event. An Asset is **Removed** when a rule or effect forces it to leave play.

- Removal applies regardless of the destination or the natural verb used by the rule or effect. An instruction may discard an Asset, put it in a Graveyard, return it to a Hand, or otherwise make it leave play and still cause Removal.

- If a player's Asset limit decreases below the number of Assets they have banked, every Asset they are forced to discard to return within that limit is **Removed**. A forced choice of which Asset leaves play still counts as Removal.
- Voluntarily discarding, spending, returning, or otherwise using one of your own Assets does **not** count as Removal unless a rule expressly says otherwise.
- An Asset leaving play through its own normal resolution, expiration, or self-removal condition does **not** count as Removal unless a rule expressly says otherwise.
- **Remove** does not itself assign a destination. Follow the rule or effect that caused the Removal.

Cards should still use the clearest natural instruction for the physical result. For example, *discard 1 Asset* is preferable to forcing the word *Remove* into the sentence when discard is the actual instruction. Use **Remove/Removed** when another rule or effect cares that involuntary Asset loss occurred.

Capitalized **Remove/Removed** carries this defined meaning. Lowercase *remove* may continue to appear in ordinary English with its contextual meaning.

Asset ownership language

When ownership is already clear from the sentence, prefer:

- your Asset / your Assets;
- opposing Asset / opposing Assets; and
- their Asset / their Assets.

Do not write *Asset you control*, *Assets you control*, *Asset they control*, or equivalent control boilerplate unless a genuine ownership or control ambiguity requires it.

Bound cards

Bind attaches one card to another for as long as the relevant effect requires.

- Unless an effect gives a different instruction, when a card leaves play, cards bound to it are put in their owners' Discard Piles.
- If a rule or card sets a maximum number of cards that may be bound to a card and that maximum decreases below the number currently bound, immediately choose and discard excess bound cards until the limit is satisfied.
- A card-specific destination or resolution for a bound card overrides these defaults.

Reveal-stage interference

A **reveal-stage interference effect** is an effect of a revealed Gambit or Tactic that reveals, negates, returns, discards, replaces, or otherwise prevents another Gambit or Tactic at that same reveal stage from applying normally.

At each Gambit or Tactic reveal stage:

1. resolve reveal-stage interference before ordinary effects at that stage;
2. if multiple interference effects remain at the same timing, use the normal shared-timing rule among them;
and
3. after interference is complete, resolve the remaining ordinary effects normally.

An effect still cannot negate or cancel a card after that card's effect has applied.

This does **not** give general priority to every *When* revealed effect. An effect that merely applies its own result, copies another effect, or replaces its own card remains an ordinary reveal effect unless it interferes with another Gambit or Tactic at that same stage.

Compact card shorthand

Routine quantitative instructions may use compact shorthand when timing, subject, source, and eligible set remain unambiguous.

Reserve and Tactics

+N *Reserve* adds N cards to the player's Reserve at the stated timing. During Reserve formation, it increases the normal Reserve size by N.

–N *Reserve* reduces that quantity by N. Any applicable minimum remains printed.

+N *Tactic* permits N additional Tactics under the shared additional-Tactic rule.

Reserve is the default Tactic source. Do not print *from Reserve* merely to restate the default. Print another source only when it overrides or narrows the default, such as:

- +1 *Tactic from Hand*
- +1 *Tactic from those cards*
- +1 *Tactic using the stored card*

A standard combined effect may therefore read:

+1 *Reserve*, +1 *Tactic*.

Cards

+N *Card* / +N *Cards* means draw N cards from your Draw Pile into your Hand.

If another player receives the draw, identify that player. If the cards go somewhere other than the Hand, state that destination instead of using this shorthand.

Optional compound procedures may remain in natural language when shorthand would obscure what is optional.

Actions

+N Action grants N additional Actions during the **current phase**. If another phase is intended, state that phase.

This expands the number of Actions permitted in the current phase rather than reopening a phase that has ended.

Resources

+N Capital, +N Influence, +N Command, and +N Conviction mean gain that amount of the named resource.

Do **not** use negative resource shorthand for costs, payments, losses, or reductions when their rules meaning differs. Continue to write spend, pay, lose, or the applicable instruction.

Resource = N sets that resource to N. Examples include Command = 2 and Conviction = 4.

Battle total

+N Battle Total adds N to your battle total.

Retreat

Retreat +N increases the distance of the retreat identified by that clause by N Positions. It modifies that retreat; it does not create a separate retreat.

If the affected player is not otherwise clear, identify them.

Advantage and disadvantage

Card faces retain natural instruction wording:

- gain advantage = gain **one instance of advantage**;
- gain double advantage = gain **two instances of advantage**;
- gain disadvantage = gain **one instance of disadvantage**.

These are additive instructions, not binary statuses.

Instances from separate cards, Territory effects, faction abilities, and other effects **stack**. No later source replaces an earlier one unless an effect expressly says so. Before rolling battle dice, combine all advantage and disadvantage affecting each player and cancel opposing instances one-for-one.

- If **N advantage** remains, roll **N + 1 dice** and use the highest result.
- If **N disadvantage** remains, roll **N + 1 dice** and use the lowest result.

- If neither remains, roll normally.

There is no fixed stacking cap unless a rule or effect expressly creates one. Two separate effects that each say `gain advantage` therefore produce double advantage; double advantage plus one disadvantage leaves one net advantage.

Effects that ignore or prevent **one disadvantage** affect only one instance unless they say otherwise.

The words Advantage, Double Advantage, and Disadvantage may still be used as rules terms when discussing the mechanic, but card-facing instructions use the natural `gain . . .` form unless another sentence structure requires equivalent wording.

Front Line

Use **Advance Front Line N**, not `+N Front Line`, to advance the Front Line by N Territories.

Card-specific qualifications such as `if able` and replacement of Occupation remain printed when they matter.

Condition prefixes

When a condition governs the entire following clause, cards may use concise prefixes such as:

- Attacker –
- Defender –
- Counterattack –
- Win –
- Lose –

The prefix scopes only the clause that follows it. More complex conditions remain in natural language.

Rerolls use the new result

When a rule or effect causes a die to be rerolled, the reroll replaces the result it rerolls and the new result is used unless the rule or effect expressly says otherwise.

Cards therefore do not need to repeat `use the new result` or `you must use the new result` after a reroll instruction.

Applying and repeating another effect

When an effect tells you to **apply** another card's effect or **repeat** an effect, resolve that effect as a new application at the current timing.

- The effect must be able to apply at the current timing, with its printed conditions and legal targets satisfied.
- The player instructed to apply or repeat the effect controls that application.
- Make all choices again and pay all costs again for each new application.
- Applying another card's effect does not play, set, choose, or otherwise move the source card unless the instruction expressly says so. The source card remains in its current zone.
- Because the source card was not played, set, or chosen again, triggers that care about those events do not occur merely because its effect was applied or repeated.
- A copied or repeated effect may create one further application if its own printed text instructs it to do so. That further application cannot create another copied or repeated effect in the same chain.

Cards therefore do not need phrases such as *as though you played it*, *as though you controlled it*, repeated instructions to leave the source card in its zone, or card-specific reminders to remake choices and repay costs.

Battles ending without a winner

When a rule or effect ends a battle **without a winner**:

- neither player wins or loses that battle; withdrawal is not a loss;
- after the battle-ending instruction resolves, unresolved Gambit or Tactic effects from that battle do not apply unless the ending effect expressly says otherwise;
- effects that already applied are not undone;
- complete any remaining non-result Aftermath procedures that are still applicable;
- clear committed cards and cards remaining in Reserve normally unless the ending effect gives them another destination; and
- apply normal positional consequences, including Occupation when applicable, based on the Player Tokens that remain after any instructed withdrawal.

An effect conditioned on a player winning or losing does not apply when the battle ends without a winner.

Cards that end a battle without a winner therefore do not need to restate ordinary cleanup, that withdrawal is not a loss, or that already-applied effects remain applied.

12. Overlays and Other Shared Card Rules

How it works

An Overlay sits on a Territory and temporarily replaces the exposed effect beneath it. Only the top Overlay is active, but covered Overlays remain attached.

The player who controls the Territory also controls its Overlays. Ownership does not change, so when an Overlay is removed, put it in its owner's Discard Pile unless its text says otherwise.

Complete rules

An Overlay is a persistent card attached to a Territory. It supersedes the printed effect immediately beneath it while exposed.

Unless an effect says otherwise:

- the top exposed Overlay is active;
- lower Overlays remain attached but dormant;
- a dormant Overlay's effect and expiration timer pause;
- a printed removal condition remains active while dormant;
- when the top Overlay leaves, the next becomes active, or the Territory's effect becomes active if none remain;
- the controller of the underlying Territory controls the Overlay and makes its choices;
- Overlay control changes when Territory control changes;
- Overlay ownership does not change;
- each Overlay faces the same direction as the Territory beneath it and rotates with it;
- an Overlay is not an Asset and does not count toward the Asset limit; and
- when removed, put it in its owner's Discard Pile unless stated otherwise.

On an Overlay, **you** means its current controller unless the text identifies its owner, the player who placed it, or another player.

Cards that become Territories

Whenever **Manifest Destiny** enters the Gauntlet as a Territory, it is a normal Territory with a normal Deed. Existing Deed purchase costs, caps, procedures, income rules, and Controlling Interest rules apply unchanged.

Part III — Factions

How Factions Work

Each player chooses one faction and one of that faction's two Leaders. The faction determines which faction cards may be included in that player's Deck, which supplemental components are prepared, which public resources or progress are tracked, and which faction-specific Actions, abilities, and procedures are available.

A **Faction Action** is a faction-specific option chosen when taking an Action. Its faction rules state whether it is legal during Opening, Denouement, or either phase. A **Faction Ability** occurs at its stated timing and does not take an Action unless it expressly says otherwise. These are distinct rule categories.

Every faction may still win by running the Gauntlet. Some factions also have an alternate victory condition. An alternate victory applies only when its complete faction rules are satisfied.

Read the shared Learn to Play rules first. Then read the chapter for the faction and Leader used in the game. Players do not need to learn every other faction before their first game, but both players should be able to inspect all public faction rules and components in use.

Faction Components

Faction packages use Leader Cards, reference cards, trackers, double-sided progress cards, shared supplies, or other public components. The relevant faction chapter identifies its exact package and starting state.

Reference cards summarize procedures but do not replace the Rulebook or the clean faction authority. If shortened reference text omits a detail, follow the complete authority text.

General use

- Keep every supplemental component face up and visible unless its own rules say otherwise.
- Begin each tracker at the faction's stated starting value and update it immediately whenever that value changes.
- For a sliding tracker, place the indicated Leader or Reference Card over the tracker. Fully cover the tracker at 0, then slide the covering card until its bottom edge aligns with the current value.
- A counter, dial, written record, or other substitute may be used when it shows the same public information clearly and unambiguously.
- A reference card is a reminder, not a separate rules authority.
- A double-sided supplemental card changes state only when its governing rule tells you to flip it. Keep any cards attached to a supplemental component with it so both players can identify the relationship.

- Supplemental components have no card value and are not eligible as Gambits, Tactics, costs, or other playable cards unless a rule explicitly says otherwise.
- Each player supplies and controls their own faction package unless a faction rule identifies a shared supply. In a mirror match, keep the two players' components separated and oriented toward their owners.

13. Military

How it works

The Military turns battle victories into **Command**, then spends Command on Leader-specific **Orders**. The General uses Orders to attack, reinforce, and pursue. The Commandant uses them to defend, repel, and capture.

Military has no alternate victory condition. It wins by running the Gauntlet.

Complete rules

Element	Military rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet.
Resource	Command, maximum 2.
Resource gain	The first time each turn you win a battle, gain 1 Command.
Faction Actions	None. Orders use their printed timings and do not spend Actions.
Leaders	General and Commandant.
Faction pool	13 Military card titles.
Unique card	Shock and Awe, cost 5; maximum one copy per Deck.

Faction Actions

Military has **no Faction Actions**. Orders are Faction Abilities used at their printed timings; they do not use an Action. Playing a Military card for its Action effect still uses the normal Action rules.

Components and setup

A Military game package includes:

- one Military Leader Card: **General** or **Commandant**;
- one Military Command Tracker; and
- any Military cards included in the Deck.

Place the chosen Leader face up. Place the Command Tracker beneath it, fully covered, to show 0 Command. Slide the Leader upward to the 1 or 2 registration line as Command changes.

Command and Orders

How it works

The first battle you win during each turn gives you 1 Command, even when you win while defending on the opponent's turn. Spend Command only when an Order reaches its printed timing.

Complete rules

Military may have up to 2 Command.

The first time each turn the Military player wins a battle, gain 1 Command. This trigger may occur during either player's turn. Winning while already at 2 Command still counts as the first Military victory of that turn.

Determine the winner, then gain normal Command before applying other effects caused by that victory. Newly gained Command may pay for an Order whose timing occurs during the Aftermath.

- Use an Order only at its printed timing.
- Spend the listed Command when the Order is used unless an effect changes the cost.
- An Order cannot be used without enough Command.
- Withdrawal has no winner, so it generates no Command and cannot satisfy a victory-dependent Order.

Leaders

General

Archetype: Attack, forward pressure, and tempo **Motto:** *Forward. Again.*

Orders

Onward — 1 Command: During your Movement, before a pending battle is created, move one additional Position. This movement may create a pending battle.

Rally — 1 Command: Before dice are rolled in a battle you initiated, add +1 to your battle total.

Rout — 2 Command: At the end of the Aftermath of a battle you initiated and won, advance one Position. This movement may create a pending battle.

Onward cannot be used after a battle. Rout creates a new movement sequence after the completed Aftermath.

Commandant

Archetype: Defense, counterattack, and control **Motto:** *We hold. They break.*

Orders

Entrench — 1 Command: Before dice are rolled in a battle you did not initiate, add +1 to your battle total.

Repel — 1 Command: During the Aftermath of a battle you did not initiate and won, after the opponent's normal retreat, they retreat one additional position, if able.

Fortify — 2 Command: During the Aftermath of a battle you won while occupying an enemy-controlled Territory, advance your Front Line by one Territory, if able.

Military-specific rules

Initiating battles

You initiated a battle when your movement or effect caused it to begin. A follow-up battle is a new battle with new Gambits, Reserves, Tactics, and once-per-battle opportunities.

Additional Tactics

Military effects may add Tactics after the normal Tactic reveal. Play such a card face up. Its effect must still be applicable at that timing. It does not reopen normal Tactic choice, Surveillance, Interference, or reveal windows.

Conflicting victory benefits

War Crimes and Shock and Awe may prohibit movement, capture, or Orders resulting from the same victory. Apply only combinations of effects that can legally be applied together.

14. Diplomats

How it works

Before a battle begins, a Diplomat may offer **Terms**. The Diplomat stakes Influence and presents a Proposal. The opponent may accept, preventing the battle, or refuse and fight under the Proposal's refusal effect.

Accepted or successfully imposed Proposals become Treaty Articles. Ratify five different Proposals and survive until the start of your next turn to win through the **Peace Treaty**.

Complete rules

Element	Diplomat rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet or complete the Peace Treaty.
Resource	Influence, minimum 0 and maximum 10.
Starting value	1 Influence.
Faction procedure	Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset.
Faction Actions	None. Terms and Leverage do not spend Actions.
Leaders	Ambassador and Senator.
Proposal set	Nine double-sided Proposal / Treaty Article cards.
Faction pool	13 Diplomat card titles.

Faction Actions

Diplomats have **no Faction Actions**. Offering Terms is a faction procedure during a pending battle before Onset, and Leverage is a Faction Ability used before dice are rolled after refused Terms. Neither takes an Action. Playing a Diplomat card for its Action effect still uses the normal Action rules.

Components and setup

A Diplomat game package includes:

- one Diplomat Leader Card: **Ambassador** or **Senator**;
- one Influence Tracker;
- one Diplomat Reference Card;
- nine double-sided Proposal / Treaty Article cards; and
- any Diplomat cards included in the Deck.

Begin with 1 Influence. Place all nine Proposals side up.

Influence and Terms

How it works

Influence pays for negotiation and can strengthen a battle after Terms are refused. To offer Terms, choose one Proposal whose Requirement is satisfied and stake its listed Influence.

If the opponent accepts, no battle is fought. If the opponent refuses, apply the Refused effect and continue to Gambits.

Complete rules

Influence

Diplomats begin with 1 Influence and may have up to 10.

When Influence is staked or spent, lower the tracker. Staked Influence is unavailable until the Terms conclude. Influence gained above 10 is lost.

Offering Terms

Terms occur during a pending battle after the attacker, defender, contested Position, and attacker's previous Position are established but before Onset.

To offer Terms:

1. choose one eligible Proposal;
2. confirm its Requirement;
3. confirm enough available Influence for its Stake;
4. lower available Influence by the Stake; and
5. the opponent accepts or refuses.

A Diplomat may normally offer one Proposal for a pending battle.

Diplomat mirrors

Only one player may offer Terms for a pending battle.

1. The attacker has the first opportunity.
2. If the attacker passes, the defender may offer.
3. Once either player offers Terms, the other cannot offer Terms for that battle, even if the Proposal is refused.

Accepted Terms

When Terms are accepted:

1. no battle begins;
2. apply the Proposal's **Accepted** effect;
3. return the Stake;
4. if the Proposal is unratified, flip it to its Treaty Article side;
5. if newly ratified, gain 1 Influence; and
6. apply effects that occur after acceptance.

Accepted Terms do not create Onset, a battle, winner, loser, retreat, or Aftermath. Unless the Proposal says otherwise, the attacker withdraws and the defender remains at the contested Position.

An already-ratified Proposal grants no default ratification reward.

Refused Terms

When Terms are refused:

1. apply the Proposal's **Refused** effect and any refusal modifiers;
2. continue to Set Gambits;
3. before dice, the Diplomat may use Leverage; and
4. continue the battle through the Aftermath.

Apply the result:

Result	Stake	Ratification	Normal reward
Diplomat wins	Return	If new, impose and flip	Gain 2 Influence if newly ratified unless stated otherwise
Diplomat loses	Lose	None	None
No winner	Return	None	None

To **impose** a Proposal is to ratify it after winning the battle caused by its refusal.

Withdrawal produces no winner. Return the Stake and do not impose the Proposal.

Leverage

Before dice are rolled in a battle following refused Terms, the Diplomat may spend Influence for Leverage:

Bonus	Total Influence cost
+1	1
+2	3
+3	6
+4	10

The progression continues without a fixed maximum. Each additional +1 costs one more Influence than the previous increment. Staked Influence cannot be spent as Leverage.

Treaty Articles and Peace Treaty

A ratified Proposal is a Treaty Article. It may be offered again for its tactical effects but cannot be ratified again and grants no normal newly-ratified Influence reward.

At the start of the Diplomat's turn, after the Capture step and before the Draw step, if five different Proposals are ratified, the Diplomat wins through the Peace Treaty.

Leaders

Ambassador

Archetype: Agreement, card flow, and settlement **Motto:** *Words first. War last.*

Cordiality: Once per turn, after the opponent accepts your Terms, draw one card.

Senator

Archetype: Risk management, resilience, and imposition **Motto:** *Procedure endures.*

Political Capital: Once per turn, when you would lose staked Influence after losing a battle following refused Terms, you may put up to that many cards from your Hand in your Graveyard. Recover 1 staked Influence for each card put there; lose the rest.

Proposal set

Proposal cards are physically presented to the receiving player. Accepted and Refused text therefore uses explicit roles rather than perspective-dependent **you** or **your**.

De-escalation

Stake: 0 **Requirement:** None

Accepted: Both players withdraw. The accepting player draws one card. **Refused:** The Diplomat draws one card.

Orderly Withdrawal

Stake: 0 **Requirement:** The Diplomat must be the attacker.

Accepted: The Diplomat withdraws. The accepting player remains at the contested Position, then draws one card. **Refused:** Add +1 to the Diplomat's battle total.

Capitulation

Stake: 0 **Requirement:** The Diplomat must be the defender.

Accepted: The Diplomat withdraws. The accepting player remains at the contested Position and becomes the occupier when applicable, then draws one card. **Refused:** If the Diplomat loses, the Diplomat draws two cards.

Open Channels

Stake: 1 **Requirement:** The Diplomat must have a card in Hand.

Accepted: Both players reveal their Hands, then both players withdraw. The accepting player draws one card. **Refused:** The refusing player reveals their Hand. When the Diplomat forms their Reserve, the Diplomat draws one additional card.

Mutual Disarmament

Stake: 1 **Requirement:** Both players must have a card in Hand.

Accepted: Each player discards one card from Hand. The accepting player draws one card, then both players withdraw. **Refused:** The Diplomat may discard one card from Hand. If they do, the Diplomat draws one additional card when forming their Reserve.

Prisoner Exchange

Stake: 1 **Requirement:** Each player must have a card in their Graveyard.

Accepted: Each player may move one card from their Graveyard to their Discard Pile. Then both players withdraw. **Refused:** If the Diplomat loses, the Diplomat may move one card from their Graveyard to their Discard Pile.

Rebuilding Pact

Stake: 1 Requirement: The Diplomat must have a card in Hand that can be banked as an Asset.

Accepted: Each player may bank one eligible card from Hand as an Asset without taking an Action. Then both players withdraw. **Refused:** During the Aftermath, the Diplomat may bank one eligible card from Hand as an Asset without taking an Action.

Ultimatum

Stake: 2 Requirement: None

Accepted: The accepting player withdraws. The Diplomat remains at the contested Position and becomes the occupier when applicable. **Refused:** Add +1 to the Diplomat's battle total.

Diplomatic Recognition

Stake: 2 Requirement: The Diplomat must be defending a Counterattack while occupying a Territory the opposing player controlled immediately before the Diplomat became its occupier.

Accepted: The Diplomat advances their Front Line by one Territory, if able. The accepting player withdraws, then draws two cards. **Refused:** If the Diplomat wins, advance the Diplomat's Front Line by one Territory during the Aftermath, if able. The Diplomat gains no Influence for imposing this Proposal.

Diplomat-specific rules

Multiple Proposals

Diplomatic Latitude may offer two eligible Proposals with the same Stake. Stake that amount once. Only the selected Proposal takes effect or may become ratified.

Sanctions

Sanctions is a shared title series, not a separate card type. A card whose title begins **Sanctions:** is a **Sanction**.

When a Sanction is played, placed, or banked because an opponent refused its owner's Terms:

- that opponent remains associated with that Sanction for as long as it remains in play; and
- unless the Sanction says otherwise, after that opponent accepts the owner's Terms, put the Sanction in its owner's Discard Pile.

A Sanction may state additional removal conditions. Cards therefore do not need to repeat identification of the refusing opponent or the default expiration after later acceptance.



15. Financiers

How it works

Financiers build economic power. They place cards in a **Treasury** to increase their Capital limit, gain and spend **Capital**, and buy **Deeds** connected to Territories.

Deed ownership is independent of token position and Territory control. Own the Deeds to every Territory currently in the Gauntlet to win through **Controlling Interest**.

Complete rules

Element	Financier rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet or achieve Controlling Interest.
Resource	Capital, minimum 0; maximum determined by the Capital limit.
Capital limit	Territories you control plus total card value in Treasury.
Financial Capacity	If Treasury value exceeds Territories controlled at the start of your turn, gain 1 additional Action that turn; at least one Action must be spent on a Financier Faction Action.
Faction Actions	Place a card in Treasury, buy or buy out a Deed, Play the Market, or use Hostile Takeover; each is taken during Denouement.
Income	After the Capture step, gain 1 Capital per Deed you own.
Leaders	Banker and Executive.
Faction pool	13 Financier card titles.
Unique card	Corner the Market, cost 5; maximum one copy per Deck.

Faction Actions

Financiers have the following Faction Actions. Each costs 1 Action and may be used only during an Denouement:

- **Place a card in Treasury:** Place one card from your Hand face up in your Treasury.
- **Buy or buy out a Deed:** Pay the full current cost to acquire one unowned Deed or buy out one opposing Financier's Deed.
- **Play the Market:** Discard one card from Hand, roll one die, and gain Capital according to the result.
- **Hostile Takeover — Executive only:** After winning a battle as the attacker that turn and becoming the occupier of the enemy Territory, buy or buy out its Deed; a successful purchase also gives you control of that Territory.

When Financial Capacity grants an additional Action, at least one Action spent that turn must be spent on one of these Faction Actions. Line of Credit modifies a Deed purchase, and Subsidize modifies a battle; neither is a separate Faction Action.

Components and setup

A Financier game package includes:

- one Financier Leader Card: **Banker** or **Executive**;
- one Financier Reference Card;
- one public Capital Ledger;
- eight identical full-size Deed Cards in a shared supply; and
- any Financier cards included in the Deck.

Begin with 2 Capital and an empty Treasury. Place Deed Cards in the shared unowned supply.

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds

How it works

Capital is public and pays for Deeds, Subsidize, and card effects. Your Capital limit rises when you control Territories or place valuable cards in Treasury. You may temporarily exceed the limit, but excess Capital is lost at the end of each turn.

At the start of your turn, if the total card value in your Treasury is greater than the number of Territories you control, gain 1 additional Action that turn. At least one Action spent that turn must be spent on a Financier Faction Action.

During an Denouement, you may spend 1 Action to place a card in Treasury, buy a Deed, or Play the Market.

Complete rules

Capital and Capital Ledger

Capital cannot fall below 0. Record every gain, spend, loss, and end-turn reduction on the public Capital Ledger, including the new running Balance.

Capital limit = Territories you control + total card value of cards in your Treasury

Capital may exceed the limit temporarily. At the end of every turn, including an opponent's turn, reduce your Capital to the current limit if necessary.

Financial Capacity

After completing the Capture step and applying all effects that occur after it, but before Draw, compare the total card value in your Treasury with the number of Territories you control.

If Treasury value is greater, you may take one Action during both Opening and Denouement that turn, provided at least one of those Actions is a Financier Faction Action. A Financier Faction Action is normally legal only during Denouement.

Financial Capacity does not permit two Actions in one phase. Determine eligibility once at this timing; later Treasury or control changes do not grant or remove the permission that turn.

Treasury

During Denouement, take an Action to place one card from your Hand face up in your Treasury.

- Treasury cards are outside normal card zones.
- They cannot be played or affected unless a rule specifically refers to Treasury.
- Each increases the Capital limit by its value.
- Treasury is not the Asset Bank and uses no Asset capacity.
- A card leaving Treasury immediately stops contributing to the limit.
- Treasury cards do not generate Capital by themselves.

Deeds

Each Territory currently in the Gauntlet has one Deed. A Deed is unowned or owned by a Financier.

When buying an unowned Deed, take a Deed Card from the supply and place it beside that Territory on the owner's side. In a Financier mirror, placement identifies ownership.

When buying out an opposing Financier's Deed, move its Deed Card to the buyer's side. When a Deed becomes unowned, return its card to the supply.

Deed ownership is independent of token position and Territory control. Changing Territory control does not transfer its Deed. A Deed is not an Asset or Overlay.

Buying and buying out Deeds

During Denouement, take an Action to buy or buy out one Deed by paying its full cost.

When an effect permits several purchases, complete each purchase before recalculating the next cost.

Deed cost = min(Deeds you own + 1, 6) + position modifier + buyout premium

Minimum cost is 1 Capital.

Territory state from buyer's perspective	Modifier
You control it	-1
You are the occupier	0
You neither control it nor are its occupier	+1

For an unowned Deed, buyout premium is 0.

For a Deed owned by an opposing Financier:

Buyout premium = min(Deeds the opposing owner owns, 6)

Income

After the Capture step at the start of your turn, gain 1 Capital for each Deed you own. Income may temporarily exceed the Capital limit.

Controlling Interest

When you own the Deeds to every Territory currently in the Gauntlet, immediately win through **Controlling Interest**.

A Territory added to the Gauntlet has a normal Deed and expands the required portfolio.

Play the Market

During Denouement, take an Action, discard one card from Hand, and roll one die:

Roll	Result
1	Put the card in your Graveyard; gain 0 Capital.
2–3	Gain 1 Capital.
4–5	Gain Capital equal to the card's value.
6	Gain Capital equal to twice the card's value.

Subsidize

Before dice are rolled in a battle involving you, spend Capital to add to your battle total.

Bonus	Total cost
+1	1 Capital
+2	3 Capital
+3	6 Capital
+4	10 Capital

The progression continues without a fixed maximum. Each additional +1 costs one more Capital than the previous increment. Capital spent through Subsidize is lost regardless of the result.

Leaders

Banker

Archetype: Collateral, planned purchases, and flexible financing **Motto:** *Credit closes the distance.*

Line of Credit: The first time on your turn that you would buy or buy out a Deed, you may use one card from your Hand or Treasury as collateral. - It contributes payment equal to its value. - It cannot contribute more than half the purchase cost, rounded down. - Pay the remaining cost with Capital. - Put the collateral in your Discard Pile after the purchase. - Unused collateral value is lost. - Line of Credit applies only to Deed purchases and buyouts.

Executive

Archetype: Offensive acquisition, Occupation, and immediate control **Motto:** *Take the ground. Close the deal.*

Hostile Takeover: During Denouement, if you won a battle as the attacker this turn and are now the occupier of that enemy Territory, you may take an Action to buy or buy out its Deed. Treat yourself as the occupier, but not the controller, for the cost calculation. If the purchase succeeds, advance your Front Line by one Territory, if able.

Financier-specific rules

Collateral

Collateral is not a separate zone. Place the collateral beneath the card or effect using it so its source and value remain visible.

- Line of Credit collateral goes to the Discard Pile after purchase.
- Margin Loan collateral returns only after repayment or a qualifying battle victory; default puts both cards in the Graveyard.
- Leveraged Buyout collateral used from battle goes to the Graveyard after the purchase.

- Collateral contributes payment value but does not become Capital unless stated.
- Unused collateral value is lost.

Added Territories

A Territory added to the Gauntlet:

- has a Deed;
- counts toward Capital and Asset limits when controlled;
- generates income when its Deed is owned;
- expands Controlling Interest; and
- uses the normal capped cost formulas.

Self-tracking cards

- Speculation remains face up beside its selected Territory and is neither an Asset nor Overlay.
- Capital Gains is placed beneath its selected Treasury card.
- Margin Loan holds its collateral beneath it.

Tariffs and Asset replacement

You cannot bank Tariffs while another copy you control is banked. During the turn Tariffs is banked, you cannot voluntarily cause it to leave play, including replacing it to make room for another Asset.

Underwriting and Property Dues may be replaced normally. Replacing Margin Loan before the loan is settled causes default.

16. Intelligence

How it works

Intelligence pursues hidden **Missions**, earns **Intel**, and builds **Operation Progress**. Intel lets the faction reveal an opponent's hidden battle choice through **Surveillance** and remove it through **Interference**.

Complete enough Missions to make a **Special Operation** ready, satisfy its hidden requirement, and pay its Intel cost to win.

Complete rules

Element	Intelligence rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet or complete a Special Operation.
Tracked values	Intel and Operation Progress; both begin at 0.
Mission reward	1 Operation Progress and Intel equal to the Mission card's value.
Battle tools	Surveillance and Interference.
Faction Actions	Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation; all are Denouement Actions.
Leaders	Ranger and Spymaster.
Faction pool	13 Intelligence card titles.
Unique card	Sleeper Network, cost 5; maximum one copy per Deck.

Faction Actions

Intelligence has the following Faction Actions. Each costs one Action and is legal only during Denouement:

- **Start a Mission:** Place one eligible Intelligence card from Hand face down as your Active Mission.
- **Complete a Mission:** Reveal a satisfied Active Mission, gain its Mission reward, and put it in your Discard Pile.
- **Abort a Mission:** Reveal the Active Mission, spend Intel equal to its value, and put it in your Discard Pile.
- **Start a Special Operation:** When ready, place one eligible Intelligence card from Hand face down as your Special Operation.
- **Complete a Special Operation:** Reveal a satisfied, ready Special Operation, pay its Intel cost, and win the game.

Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control are Faction Abilities, not Faction Actions. Mission Control may start a Mission without spending an Action only because its text expressly permits it.

Components and setup

An Intelligence game package includes:

- one Intelligence Leader Card: **Ranger** or **Spymaster**;
- one Mission Reference Card;
- one Operations Reference Card;
- one Intel Tracker;
- one Operation Progress Tracker; and
- any Intelligence cards included in the Deck.

Both values begin at 0 and have no maximum. Only an Intelligence card with a printed **Mission** requirement may become an Active Mission or Special Operation.

Intel, Missions, and Special Operations

How it works

During Denouement, take an Action to place an eligible card face down as your Active Mission. Once you have satisfied its requirement on a later turn, spend 1 Action during another Denouement to reveal and complete it.

A completed Mission gives 1 Operation Progress and Intel equal to the card's value. When Operation Progress exceeds the number of Territories the opponent controls, you may begin a Special Operation.

Complete rules

Intel

Intel begins at 0, cannot fall below 0, and has no maximum. Spend it for Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, Mission abortion, Special Operation completion, and card effects.

Operation Progress

Operation Progress begins at 0 and is not normally spent. Each completed normal Mission adds 1, regardless of card value.

Starting a Mission

During Denouement, take an Action to place one eligible Intelligence card from your Hand face down near your Leader as your **Active Mission**.

- You may inspect it at any time.
- You may have only one Active Mission.
- You cannot have an Active Mission and Special Operation simultaneously.
- It cannot complete during the turn it begins.
- Its printed requirement counts only while it is the Active Mission.
- Starting it is not playing the card for a printed effect.

Completing a Mission

During Denouement, take an Action to reveal and complete the Active Mission if its requirement has been satisfied.

1. Gain 1 Operation Progress.
2. Gain Intel equal to its value.
3. Put it in your Discard Pile.

Satisfying the requirement does not complete it automatically.

Aborting and failing

During Denouement, take an Action, reveal the Active Mission, and spend Intel equal to its value to abort it. Put it in the Discard Pile. Aborting is not failure.

A Mission fails only when a rule, effect, or continuing requirement causes failure. Reveal it and put it in the Graveyard.

Starting a Special Operation

You may start a Special Operation only when:

- your Operation Progress exceeds the number of Territories the opponent controls;
- you have no Active Mission or Special Operation; and
- you have an eligible Intelligence card in Hand.

During Denouement, take an Action to place that card face down as your Special Operation.

A Special Operation uses the printed Mission requirement but is not a normal Mission. It grants no Mission reward and does not trigger normal-Mission effects.

Readiness and completion

The Special Operation remains ready only while Operation Progress exceeds the number of Territories the opponent controls. If readiness is lost, it immediately fails and goes to the Graveyard.

During an Denouement, if its requirement is satisfied and readiness remains valid, spend 1 Action, reveal it, and pay:

Territories currently in the Gauntlet – Special Operation card's value

Minimum payment is 1 Intel. If paid, immediately win through Special Operation.

Surveillance and Interference

How it works

Intelligence gets two separate chances to use Surveillance in each battle: one against an opposing Gambit and one against opposing Tactics. Spend 1 Intel for each face-down card revealed.

Immediately after revealing a card, spend 2 more Intel to interfere. The card returns to its source, and the opponent may replace it from that same source or pass.

Complete rules

Gambit Surveillance

Once per battle, after the opponent sets a face-down Gambit, spend 1 Intel to reveal it.

After you use any Interference against that revealed Gambit and the opponent makes any replacement, you may revise your own Gambit choice if you have already made one. Revision does not create another Surveillance or Interference opportunity.

Tactic Surveillance

Once per battle, after the opponent chooses one or more face-down Tactics, spend 1 Intel for each opposing Tactic you reveal.

After you use any Interference against those revealed Tactics and the opponent makes replacements, you may revise your own Tactic choices if you have already made them. Revision does not create another Surveillance or Interference opportunity.

The Gambit and Tactic opportunities are independent. Using one does not consume the other.

Interference after Surveillance

Immediately after revealing a card through Surveillance, spend 2 additional Intel per revealed card you remove.

- A removed Gambit returns to its owner's Hand.

- A removed Tactic returns to its owner's Reserve.
- The owner may choose one eligible replacement from the same source or pass.
- A replacement is placed face down unless the effect says otherwise.
- The replacement creates no new Surveillance, Interference, reveal, or response opportunity.

If an effect prevents Surveillance or Interference, the Intel remains spent and the relevant once-per-battle opportunity is still used.

Direct Interference

When an opposing effect sets or chooses a card face up and the normal Surveillance reveal is unnecessary, Intelligence may spend 2 Intel to Interfere with that card directly at the same response timing. This does not use Surveillance but does use the relevant stage's Interference opportunity.

Intelligence mirrors

At each choice stage:

1. the first player makes the relevant choice;
2. the second player may use Surveillance and Interference, then makes their choice;
3. the first player may use Surveillance and Interference, then revise their own choice if allowed; and
4. the stage closes.

Leaders

Ranger

Archetype: Territory effects, reconnaissance, and field operations **Motto:** *Know the land before the battle begins.*

Fieldcraft: Once per turn, when a printed Territory effect would affect you, your movement, or a battle involving you, you may spend 1 Intel to ignore that Territory effect until the end of the turn.

Fieldcraft does not alter Territory control, Occupation, Capture, Defensive Edge, Last Stand bonuses, or limits calculated from Territories.

Spymaster

Archetype: Mission tempo and operational coordination **Motto:** *Information never rests. Momentum is the weapon.*

Mission Control: Once per turn, after completing a normal Mission, you may immediately start another eligible Mission from your Hand without spending an Action. It cannot complete that turn. Mission Control cannot start a Special Operation.

Intelligence-specific rules

Counterintelligence

Counterintelligence prevents an opposing effect from revealing a Hand, Reserve, or face-down battle card. It prevents the entire opposing revealing effect, not only the information portion. Rules-mandated reveals are unaffected.

Watchtower

When the controller of Watchtower defends there, the attacker sets their Gambit face up or passes; the defender sets normally. Because the attacker's Gambit was never face down, Counterintelligence does not prevent the reveal. Intelligence may use Direct Interference for 2 Intel.

17. Mystics

How it works

Mystics sacrifice, bind, exchange, and recover cards while completing three public **Rites**. The first completed Rite unlocks **Invocation**, the second unlocks **Transmutation**, and the third unlocks **Convergence** and the ability to begin the **Ritual of Ascendancy**.

To win through Ritual, bind three cards from three different zones, initiate a battle while they remain bound, and win that battle.

Complete rules

Element	Mystics rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet or complete the Ritual of Ascendancy.
Resource	None.
Trait	All thirteen Mystics cards have the Arcane trait.
Progression	First Rite: Invocation; second: Transmutation; third: Convergence and Ritual.
Faction Actions	Begin a Rite or, after all three Rites are complete, begin the Ritual of Ascendancy; both are normally Denouement Actions.
Leaders	Alchemist and Spirit Walker.
Faction pool	13 Mystics card titles.
Unique card	Necromancy, cost 5; maximum one copy per Deck.

Faction Actions

Mystics have the following Faction Actions. Each costs one Action and is normally legal only during Denouement:

- **Begin a Rite:** Choose one incomplete Rite you may legally begin and pay its beginning cost.
- **Begin the Ritual of Ascendancy:** After completing all three Rites, bind the required Arcane cards from Hand, Discard Pile, and Graveyard.

Completing a Rite is not a Faction Action; it occurs when that Rite's completion condition and timing are satisfied. Invocation, Transmutation, Convergence, and the Leader abilities are Faction Abilities, not Faction Actions.

Components and setup

A Mystics game package includes:

- one Mystics Leader Card: **Alchemist** or **Spirit Walker**;
- one Mystics Reference Card;
- three double-sided Rite cards: **Rite of Echoes**, **Rite of Blood**, and **Rite of Crossing**; and
- any Mystics cards included in the Deck.

Place all three Rite cards incomplete side up. Mystics use no resource tracker.

Rites and progression

How it works

During Denouement, take an Action and pay a Rite's beginning cost to begin it. You may have only one begun but incomplete Rite at a time, and a Rite cannot complete on the turn it begins.

Once its condition is met on a later turn, complete it and unlock the next faction ability. Completed Rites remain complete.

Complete rules

Beginning a Rite

During Denouement, take an Action to begin one incomplete Rite by paying its beginning cost.

- You may have only one begun but incomplete Rite.
- You may begin any uncompleted Rite; there is no required order.
- A Rite cannot complete during the turn it begins.
- Only one Rite may be completed per turn.
- If interrupted, it resets and paid costs are not returned unless stated.

Progression

- Complete the first Rite to unlock **Invocation**.
- Complete the second Rite to unlock **Transmutation**.
- Complete the third Rite to unlock **Convergence** and permission to begin the **Ritual of Ascendance**.

Bound cards

Bound cards follow the shared rules. If a Rite or Ritual binding ends without another instruction, put its bound cards in their owners' Graveyards.

Invocation

Once per turn, after applying the Action, Gambit, Tactic, or Gambit or Tactic effect of an Arcane card you played, set, or chose, you may move one card from your Graveyard to your Discard Pile.

A copied effect does not trigger Invocation unless the Arcane card is itself played, set, or chosen again and its printed effect is applied.

Transmutation

Once per turn, before dice are rolled in a battle involving you, you may put one card from your Hand in your Graveyard. Add its value to your battle total.

The card is not played and none of its printed effects apply. Supplemental components cannot be used.

The three Rites

Rite of Echoes

Beginning cost: Bind one chosen card from your Graveyard face up beneath this Rite. Then bind one card from your Hand face down beneath it whose title matches at least one other card in your Deck.

Completion: On a later turn, complete this Rite after the Gambit, Tactic, or Gambit or Tactic effect of another card with the bound Hand card's title is applied during a battle.

On completion:

- move the selected Graveyard card to your Discard Pile;
- put the bound Hand card in your Graveyard;
- apply the completing card normally; and
- flip Rite of Echoes to its completed side.

If you lose a battle before completion, put both bound cards in your Graveyard and reset the Rite.

Rite of Blood

Beginning cost: Put one card from your Hand in your Graveyard.

Completion: On a later turn, complete this Rite when you win a battle without setting a Gambit or choosing a Tactic.

Using Transmutation, an Asset, Overlay, Territory, Leader ability, or card from another source does not by itself prevent completion.

If you lose a battle before completion, reset the Rite.

Rite of Crossing

You may take the Begin a Rite Faction Action for Rite of Crossing during Denouement only after winning a battle that turn that made you the occupier of a Territory the opponent controlled immediately before that battle.

Beginning cost: Put one Arcane card from your Hand in your Graveyard. If you have none, reveal your Hand and move one Arcane card from your Discard Pile to your Graveyard instead.

Completion: At the start of your next turn, after the Capture step, complete this Rite if you are still the occupier or now control that Territory. Otherwise, the Rite is interrupted and resets.

Ritual of Ascendance and Convergence

How it works

After completing all three Rites, spend 1 Action during an Denouement to bind one Arcane card from your Hand, one from your Discard Pile, and one from your Graveyard. This begins the Ritual.

Initiate a battle while all three remain bound. Convergence adds +1 for each Ritual card. Win that battle to win the game. Lose any battle before completion and the Ritual is interrupted.

Complete rules

Beginning the Ritual

After completing all three Rites, during an Denouement, spend 1 Action to bind:

- one Arcane card from your Hand;
- one Arcane card from your Discard Pile; and
- one Arcane card from your Graveyard.

This begins the Ritual of Ascendance.

Convergence

While the Ritual is underway, during a battle you initiated, add +1 to your battle total for each card bound to the Ritual.

With all three cards bound, Convergence normally gives +3.

Completion

Initiate a battle while all three Ritual cards remain bound. If you win that battle, complete the Ritual and immediately win the game.

The Mystic must initiate the final battle.

Interruption

If you lose any battle before Ritual completion, the Ritual is interrupted. Put all three Ritual-bound cards in your Graveyard.

Completed Rites remain complete. You may begin the Ritual again later.

Withdrawal neither completes nor interrupts the Ritual because it has no winner or loser.

Leaders

Alchemist

Archetype: Sacrifice sequencing and card conversion **Motto:** *Nothing is fixed. Everything can be transformed.*

Materia Prima: The first time on your turn that you put a card from your Hand in your Graveyard as part of a Rite, Transmutation, or an Arcane card effect, draw one card. If this occurs during a battle, draw after the Aftermath of the battle.

A Gambit does not trigger Materia Prima merely because it moves from battle to your Graveyard during the Aftermath.

Spirit Walker

Archetype: Rite endurance and protective sacrifice **Motto:** *The spirits remember what the living abandon.*

Guardians of the Circle: The first time on your turn that you lose a battle and that loss would interrupt a begun Rite or your Ritual of Ascendance, you may put one Arcane card from your Hand in your Graveyard whose value is at least 1 plus the number of Rites you have completed. If you do, prevent that interruption.

Guardians of the Circle cannot preserve a continuing position requirement.

Mystics-specific rules

Arcane trait

Arcane is a trait, not faction allegiance. Mystics cards are Arcane, and cards from other pools may also have the trait.

Entering the Graveyard

A card enters the Graveyard before an effect such as Grave Ward moves it elsewhere. An entry trigger still applies even if the card immediately leaves.

Exchange

To exchange two cards, move each simultaneously to the other's previous zone. Both must remain eligible and present. If either cannot move, no exchange occurs.

Repeating Gambit or Tactic effects

Witchcraft and similar effects follow the shared copied-effect rules. A repeat effect cannot choose another repeat or card-adding effect unless it expressly permits one additional layer.

18. Inquisition

How it works

The Inquisition gains **Conviction** when opposing cards are permanently lost after battles. It also sends opposing Tactics to the Graveyard through **Condemnation** and gains additional Conviction when the opponent plays or reveals Arcane cards through **Blasphemy**.

Spend Conviction on **Purges** that remove cards and Assets. The first time on your turn that you spend an Action to Purge, gain 1 additional Action that turn. If the opponent eventually cannot make their normal start-of-turn draw because both their Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty, win through **Purification**.

Complete rules

Element	Inquisition rule
Victory	Run the Gauntlet or achieve Purification.
Resource	Conviction, maximum 4.
Normal gain	First time each turn opposing cards enter the Graveyard during the Aftermath of a battle involving you.
Doctrine	Condemnation and Blasphemy.
Faction Actions	Purge — Opening or Denouement. If one phase Action is Purge, the Inquisition may take one Action in the other phase as well.
Leaders	Grand Inquisitor and Witch Hunter.
Faction pool	13 Inquisition card titles.
Arcane card	Heresy.

Faction Actions

Purge is the Inquisition's only Faction Action.

Purge — Opening or Denouement: Spend one Action and the listed Conviction to perform one Purge. You may take one Action during both Opening and Denouement that turn, provided one of those Actions is Purge.

- Purge may occupy either Action phase.
- The other Action must occupy the other phase.
- Purge never permits two Actions in one phase.
- Purge may be taken as a Faction Action no more than once per turn.

- A Purge directly permitted without taking an Action, such as Final Judgment, is separate and does not consume the once-per-turn Purge Faction Action or activate the two-phase permission.

Components and setup

An Inquisition game package includes:

- one Inquisition Leader Card: **Grand Inquisitor** or **Witch Hunter**;
- one Inquisition Doctrine Reference Card;
- one Purge Reference Card;
- one Conviction Tracker; and
- any Inquisition cards included in the Deck.

Begin with 0 Conviction. Slide the Leader over the tracker to show 0–4.

Conviction, doctrine, Purge, and Purification

How it works

The first time opposing cards enter the Graveyard during the Aftermath of a battle involving you each turn, gain 1 Conviction. Opposing Tactics go there instead of the Discard Pile, making battle choices more costly against the Inquisition.

During Opening or Denouement, take an Action and spend Conviction to Purge. If one phase Action is Purge, you may also take one Action in the other phase that turn. You may take the Purge Faction Action no more than once per turn.

Complete rules

Conviction

Conviction: Maximum 4. The first time each turn one or more opposing cards enter the Graveyard during the Aftermath of a battle involving you, gain 1 Conviction.

- This may occur during either player's turn.
- Several qualifying cards from the same battle still produce only 1 normal gain.
- Winning is not required.
- Conviction above 4 is lost.

Condemnation

Condemnation: During the Aftermath of battles involving you, opposing Tactics go to their owner's Graveyard instead of their Discard Pile.

Opposing Gambits already go to the Graveyard normally. Cards remaining in the opponent's Reserve are discarded normally.

Blasphemy

Blasphemy: Whenever an opponent plays a card with the Arcane trait for its Action effect, or an Arcane Gambit or Tactic they control is revealed, gain 1 Conviction.

This gain is outside the normal once-per-turn Conviction gain but cannot exceed 4. Merely copying an Arcane card's effect does not count as playing or revealing that card and does not trigger Blasphemy unless the effect says otherwise. Arcane is a trait, not faction allegiance.

Purge

During Opening or Denouement, take an Action and spend Conviction to Purge:

Cost	Purge
1	Choose one: put the top card of the opponent's Discard Pile in their Graveyard; or choose up to two cards there with combined value 2 or less and put them in their Graveyard.
2	Choose one opposing Asset and put it in its owner's Graveyard.
3	The opponent chooses one card from their Hand and puts it in their Graveyard.
4	Reveal the opponent's Hand. Choose one card and put it in their Graveyard.

If one Action that turn is Purge, you may take one Action in the other Action phase as well. This never permits two Actions in one phase. You may take the Purge Faction Action no more than once per turn. A directly permitted Purge is separate.

A Purge is not playing a card.

Purification

At the beginning of the opponent's turn, after their normal start-of-turn draw attempt, if they draw no cards because both their Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty, immediately win through **Purification**.

A failed Reserve draw or effect-generated draw does not trigger Purification.

Leaders

Grand Inquisitor

Archetype: Judgment, Purge, and permanent removal **Motto:** *We judge. We purge.*

Final Judgment: Once per turn, during the Aftermath of a battle you won, after battle cards are cleared and effects triggered by those moves are applied, you may immediately Purge without taking an Action. Reduce that Purge's Conviction cost by 1, to a minimum of 1.

The normal Conviction gain from that battle may occur before Final Judgment. Final Judgment is a Faction Ability. It does not consume the once-per-turn Purge Faction Action and does not activate the two-phase Purge permission.

Witch Hunter

Archetype: Defense, retaliation, and pursuit **Motto:** *You ran. I followed.*

Relentless Pursuit: Once per turn, at the end of the Aftermath of a battle an opponent initiated against you and lost, you may spend 2 Conviction. End their turn, then advance one Position. This movement may create a pending battle; you are the attacker. Do not create an Opening or Denouement phase before that pending battle.

Accepted Terms may still prevent the resulting battle from reaching Onset.

Withdrawal has no loser, so neither Leader ability triggers from it.

Inquisition-specific rules

Discard Pile order

The top card is the most recently placed card unless a rule changes the order. Choosing cards from a Discard Pile does not reorder the rest.

Combined card value

When an effect allows several cards within a combined value limit, add their printed values. The total cannot exceed the limit.

No Martyrs

No Martyrs prevents the losing opponent from benefiting from effects they control that trigger from that loss or resulting retreat. It does not prevent harmful consequences, the retreat itself, or effects controlled by another player.

Heresy and copied effects

Heresy follows the shared copied-effect rule but retains permission for one additional copied-effect layer. That additional effect cannot create another layer. The selected Graveyard card remains there.

Part IV — Reference

Quick Turn Reference

1. **Capture:** advance the active player's Front Line by at most one Territory if the normal Capture requirement is met; apply after-Capture effects and victory checks.
 2. **Draw:** draw one card.
 3. **Opening:** take the turn's Action here if desired and legal.
 4. **Movement:** Advance, Hold, or Fall Back; resolve any pending battle immediately.
 5. **Denouement:** take the turn's Action here if it was not already taken, unless another rule permits an additional Action.
 6. **Cleanup:** apply end-of-turn effects, discard down to three cards, expire unused turn permissions, and pass the active-player marker if used.
-

Quick Battle Reference

1. Entering the opponent's position creates a **pending battle**.
 2. Resolve applicable **Terms** before the battle begins.
 3. If the pending battle continues, **Onset** begins the battle.
 4. Set Gambits.
 5. Set Hands aside and form Reserves.
 6. Reveal Gambits.
 7. Choose Tactics.
 8. Reveal Tactics.
 9. Apply pre-dice effects and determine the Outcome.
 10. A defender with **Defensive Edge** wins tied battle totals; otherwise make a straight, unmodified **Tiebreak Roll**.
 11. Proceed to the Aftermath. Gambits normally go to Graveyards; Tactics and remaining Reserve cards normally go to Discard Piles.
-

Glossary

Action: A spendable allowance. A player normally takes 1 Action total each turn.

Opening: The Action phase before Movement.

Deck: The constructed set of ordinary playable cards selected under Deck-construction rules.

Draw Pile: The shuffled in-play pile formed from the Deck during setup.

Denouement: The Action phase after Movement and any battle caused by it.

Faction Action: A faction-specific option chosen when taking an Action. Its rules state its legal phase.

Faction Ability: A faction-specific effect used or triggered at its stated timing. It does not take an Action unless it expressly says otherwise.

Aftermath: The closing part of an active battle, including result or no-winner handling, retreat or withdrawal, Occupation, battle-card clearing, and follow-up effects.

Asset: A persistent card banked face up in the Asset Bank.

Control: Authority over a Territory for rules purposes, shown by the direction the Territory faces and constrained by the Front Line rules.

Counterattack: A battle initiated by the controller of a Territory against the occupier of that Territory.

Defensive Edge: A tie-breaking rule. When the defender has Defensive Edge, the defender wins tied battle totals.

Fall Back: The ordinary Movement choice that moves one position toward your own end. Fall Back is neither retreat nor withdrawal.

Front Line: The complete unbroken sequence of Territories a player controls beginning at their own end of the Gauntlet.

Gambit: An optional battle card set from Hand. It normally goes to the Graveyard during the Aftermath.

Last Stand: A battle beyond the opponent's end. It is an independent Run-the-Gauntlet route and requires a separate legal movement sequence, not prior capture or control of the final Territory.

Occupation: The state in which a player's token is on an opposing Territory that player does not control.

Occupier: A player in Occupation.

Onset: The formal opening stage of an active battle. A pending battle becomes a battle during Onset.

Pending battle: The state after attacker, defender, contested position, and attacker's previous position are established but before Onset. Terms resolve here.

Position: A Territory or off-board space where a Player Token may be placed.

Reserve: The temporary private cards drawn for one battle. Reserve is separate from Hand.

Retreat: Forced displacement after losing a battle. Retreat is not ordinary movement or withdrawal.

Tactic: An optional battle card chosen from Reserve. It normally goes to the Discard Pile during the Aftermath.

Tiebreak Roll: A separate sudden-death roll used when a tied battle total is not otherwise resolved. Each player rolls one unmodified die; reroll further ties.

Withdrawal: Leaving a pending or active battle without determining a winner. Withdrawal is not Fall Back or retreat.

Copyright and Playtest Use

Gauntlet is an unpublished playtest project.

Copyright © 2026 Tymon Scott. All rights reserved.

Repository and release materials are provided for private review and playtesting only. They may not be copied, redistributed, sold, republished, or used to create commercial derivative works without written permission.